

The rhetoric of war has changed. Not for the better

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Fitting literary allusions are out. Jarring clips from Hollywood movies are in



illustration: matt chase

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It is June 6th 1944. The second world war is in its fifth year. Millions are dead. Much of Europe lies in ruins. The fate of the war now hangs on a single stretch of water. In the English Channel 150,000 troops mass. The American president addresses his people. But despite the bloodshed, his mood is not bloodthirsty. Americans fight, he says, “not for the lust of conquest. They fight to end conquest.” His ally [Winston Churchill](#) will match this tone in his history, which he opens with a “moral”. “*in war*: resolution. *in defeat*: defiance. *in victory*: magnanimity”.

It is now April 2026. America is embroiled in another war. This war, too, hangs on a stretch of water, this time the Strait of Hormuz. The American president addresses his people. The tone is belligerent. He says: “Open the Fuckin’ Strait, you crazy bastards, or you’ll be living in Hell—just watch!” His secretary of war, Pete Hegseth, says the Iranians are “toast and they know it”. This is not a “fair fight”: “We are punching them while they’re down, which is exactly how it should be.”

War in the West has changed. Militarily, of course—stealth bombers have replaced Spitfires—but it has changed oratorically too. To talk about oratory in modern politics feels anachronistic: budget speeches do not abound in alliteration and assonance. But the words of war are different. Hitherto, when the West has waged war, it has almost always done so with modern weapons but antique words.

Thus while countries fought on the beaches and on the landing grounds with guns and bombs and bullets they also—and with equal strategy—fought on the page and on the podium and on the wireless. There were [Shakespearean](#) allusions and nods to [Abraham Lincoln](#) and rolling repetitions of the word “fight”. Oratory mattered. “Of all the talents bestowed upon men,” Churchill wrote, few are “so powerful” and “none is so precious ”

Its power seems to have been forgotten. A recent White House video titled “Justice the American Way” is an almost wordless montage of images from [“Gladiator”](#), “Top Gun” and “Transformers”, interspersed with footage of actual Iranian targets being hit. Instead of quoting the Bible, Mr Hegseth misquoted it. On April 15th he led people in a prayer that “reflected” Ezekiel 25:17—but which was actually taken almost verbatim from “Pulp Fiction”, a less celebrated spiritual work. (The actual Ezekiel verse is about God smiting the Philistines.)

An obvious counter-argument is to say: so what? Death does not distinguish between a leader who can produce a Periclean flourish and one who can’t. Moreover, winged words—as poets during the first world war pointed out—can be deceptive, luring men to a mechanised slaughter that is neither “dulce” nor decorous. When Rudyard Kipling’s only son was killed in the Battle of Loos, he wrote the bitter, un-Kiplingish epigram: “If any question why we died,/Tell them, because our fathers lied.” Butchery can be ill-served by oratory.

Yet it is hard not to feel that something is lost when a Western leader channels “Transformers” rather than Churchill. Allusion was once essential to oratory. Sensibly so: all men may be created equal, but all men’s words are not. Just ask the poor chap who gave a (now largely forgotten) two-hour, 13,607-word address at Gettysburg before Lincoln gave his 271-word zinger.

All great orators have thus borrowed, invoked, alluded. When Colonel Tim Collins sent British soldiers into Iraq he told them to “tread lightly” as they trod on the site of the Garden of Eden. The “few” of Churchill’s Battle of Britain speech stood shoulder to shoulder in the imagination with the “happy few” of Shakespeare’s “Henry V”. The atomic bomb was ushered in by a flash and by the Bhagavad Gita. “I

am become death,” J. Robert Oppenheimer would later say, “the destroyer of worlds.”

This isn’t merely oratorical fireworks. The right quotation conscripts the dead along with the living; marshal the right quotation and you marshal not merely words, but a battalion of ideas. Invoke the Bible and, tacitly, you invoke the better angels of our nature. Call upon Shakespeare’s “Henry V” and, implicitly, you also call upon God, Harry, England and St George. A tenth of all Churchill’s speeches, says Andrew Roberts, his biographer, referred to history to encourage listeners to see the war “in its historical context, of threats that had been posed to Britain in the past” that the country had defeated.

Cultural allusions offer sinew-stiffening encouragement. They also enable a speaker to “elevate the tone”, says Barry Strauss, a professor of military history at Cornell University. Pericles’s funeral oration does not merely tell Athenians to fight. He tells them they are “fighting for something...for democracy”. In 1940 Franklin Roosevelt declared that “Never before since Jamestown and Plymouth Rock has our American civilisation been in such danger as now.” America would support Allied countries; by rearming, it would become “the great arsenal of democracy”.

Leaders must evoke the right cultural allusions, however. William Nicholson, one of the writers of “Gladiator”, finds it “terrifying” that the White House is quoting the film: it “tells you that they actually see war as a Hollywood movie”. In fact, they see it less clearly than one. Mr Nicholson made the gladiator a reluctant fighter. Maximus was not a violent lunk, but a peaceable man forced to fight for his wife, child and the “dream that was Rome”. War is not fun. As Roosevelt once said: “I have seen war on land and sea. I have seen blood running from the wounded...I hate war.”

For as Hollywood knows—but the White House no longer does—the best war oratory is not actually about war. It is

does—the best war oratory is not actually about war. It is about peace. People hear it and think not merely of the lives that might be lost, but of a way of life that might be: they fear for culture, for democracy, for decency. You weep at good oratory because you fear not just a lost war but a lost world. Yet when you watch the White House videos, you weep for a lost world anyway. ■